

Pocket PC

The latest version of this platform which debuted in April 2000, is called the Windows Mobile 2003. The Microsoft handheld platform enjoys its own fan-following amidst users and application developers. The latest version sees significant improvements in communications and multimedia, with an improved Connection Manager for setting up connections, the inclusion of Pocket MSN for instant messaging, and a new application for viewing and editing images, called Pictures.

Toshiba Pocket PC e350

A PC in your pocket

The e350 is extremely light, and has a gunmetal finish that gives it an elegant but serious look. Measuring 8 x 12.5 x 1.24 cms, the e350 is a mere 149 grams, and runs Microsoft Pocket PC 2003. Its 3.5-inch TFT colour screen can reproduce up to 65,536 colours at a 240 x 320 resolution. Horsepower for the e350 is provided by a 300MHz Intel PXA255 XScale processor, complemented by 16 MB of ROM and 64 MB RAM.

The package comes with a detailed user manual and a leather carry pouch. On the front face are four application buttons, a five-way navigation pad, and a speaker, with a voice-recorder button and a jog dial on the left of the device. The installed application set includes most applications you'd need; there are also two games—Jawbreaker and Solitaire. However, the e350 misses out on an image viewer/editor application.

The transfective screen is bright and crisp in most lighting conditions, though you may like to keep the backlight on most of the time. Sound output is average even if you crank up the vol-



ume. For a Windows user, migrating to the e350 should not be a major issue. Text input options include an onscreen soft keyboard, Letter Recogniser, Block Recogniser and Transcriber. The characters appear as typed text on the screen. The Block Recogniser is useful for those familiar with the Graffiti tool. Using the Transcriber, you can write complete sentences anywhere on the screen, and the device converts them to text after a short pause.

Getting the e350 to talk to a PC is fairly simple. If your computer has an Infrared port, you can sync wirelessly. In case you don't, you need to connect the supplied docking cradle to the USB port after installing ActiveSync on the computer.

The power source for the e350 is a 1,000 mAh Lithium Ion internal battery. The power adaptor can be plugged into the docking cradle and also directly into the device. Battery life is about 5 hours with continuous use and intermittent use of the backlight.

The e350 is a neat device for a professional on the move. However, the price tag of Rs 29,990 may put it out of reach for most.

Price: Rs 29,900
+ Various options for text input
- Expensive

Toshiba Pocket PC e350		B-
Performance	▬ ▬ ▬ ▬ ▬	
Features	▬ ▬ ▬ ▬ ▬	
Ease of use	▬ ▬ ▬ ▬ ▬	
Value for money	▬ ▬ ▬ ▬ ▬	

The Pocket PC Platform and applications

Pocket PC is a young entrant to the world of handhelds. It is therefore understandable that the variety of software that is available for a Palm solution, is simply not present on this Microsoft platform. Nevertheless, there is a healthy variety of software available.

Personal Information Managers

In the Personal Information Manager (PIM) category, two solutions are widely used: Pocket Informant and Agenda Fusion. The difference is minimal—both allow for multiple views of your scheduled appointments, such as monthly and daily; moreover, alarms can be set for individual notes while templates help ease setting up of common tasks.

Also available for the Pocket PC is ListPro, which helps in organising To-do lists and the like. While it is not as feature rich as the others, it's not bad performance-wise. If you're looking for simple appointment management software, SPB Pocket Plus, with its Repeating Alarms, can help.



Pocket Informant replaces built-in PIM applications with better versions, along with cool additions

Password Managers

To manage passwords, the Pocket PC platform has a pretty comprehensive solution. eWallet stores information in password-protected categories. You're first required to supply a password, based upon which the encryption key is generated. This allows for greater security—eWallet does not store the password in your wallet file, or anywhere on your PDA or PC.

Nice Start protects the entire handheld using password protected access. To provide greater security, it can lock your handheld after a certain number of incorrect password entries. It also has the ability to log all password activities, thus allowing you to find out if someone tried to use your device without your knowledge.



Categories help organise sensitive information into individual cards